

have been made strongly and sadly evident. The list of those who have descended abruptly from the heights is long, and only a few need be mentioned. Mr. Michael Milken, perhaps the most spectacular figure of the last boom and certainly the best paid, is a recent resident in a minimum-security gaol, which, if not wholly uncomfortable, could not have seemed personally rewarding. One supposes that he met each new day without enthusiasm. Mr. Donald Trump is said not to be broke; he was, however, described in recent news accounts as having a negative net worth. These distinctions are no doubt important in the world of finance. The Reichman brothers, with Robert Campeau the Canadian gift to financial excess, are indubitably broke with depressive effect on the banks that were captured by their euphoric mood. Perhaps it is to their credit that, like Donald Trump, they erected monuments that will long commemorate their adventure. In London, tourists going down the Thames to the Tower will extend their journey to encompass the Canary Wharf development, perhaps the most awesome recent example of speculative dementia.

To a marked extent, the speculative orgy of the eighties was in real estate, including that financed through the S & L's by the guaranteeing American taxpayer. Salomon Brothers of Wall Street recently estimated that it will be an average of twelve years before presently empty commercial real estate will be absorbed. Alas for averages. They think it will be an estimated twenty-six years in Boston, forty-six years in New York and fifty-six years down in San Antonio, Texas (the leader, so to speak), in this provision for the future.

However, the effects of the splurge extend far beyond real estate and range from the serious to the sad. New Yorkers can hardly escape a tear when they see the efforts of R. H. Macy, one of their great civic symbols, to stay alive and pay for the goods it sells and the pressing charges of those who supervise it in bankruptcy. The cause of the difficulties of this great institution are not in doubt: it was the heavy load of debt incurred in the effort to obtain and retain control during the years of financial pillage and devastation. Across the country other enterprises were similarly afflicted and are similarly oppressed with the resulting debt. Oppressed with them are the banks that sustained the real estate speculation and provided credit for the mergers and acquisitions, hostile takeovers and leveraged buyouts, and the other exercises in financial devastation.